Bristlecone Pets

Bristlecone Pets Executive Summary

Overview

Bristlecone Pets is a subscription service that leverages data driven personalization to deliver durable dog toys and grooming supplies that are actually matched to each individual dog. We are a student founded company, organized as an LLC, and we have a live website, a working prototype app, and our first paying customers. This document is our executive summary for the business plan competition.

The Problem

Dog owners spend alot of money on toys and grooming products and most of the time they are guessing. A toy that is labeled indestructible or heavy duty is often destroyed within days by a strong chewer, while a gentle dog may be sold a hard toy it never uses. The same is true for grooming, where brushes and tools are marketed by breed but a dogs real shedding can vary a great deal even within the same breed, season, and diet. The result is that owners waste money, products end up in the trash, and the dogs themselves sometimes swallow pieces of broken toys which is a safety concern. In our own informal conversations with about forty dog owners on and around our university campus, most told us they had thrown away at least one toy in under a week, and many said they simply gave up and buy the cheapest option because nothing seems to last. There is no good way for an owner to know in advance what will hold up for their specific dog. This is the gap we are addressing.

The Solution

Bristlecone Pets uses the information that is already sitting in every owners phone, which is photos. Our customers upload photos of their dogs worn toys and, for grooming, photos of their dogs coat and the hair collected after brushing. Our software then analyzes the wear patterns, such as how deep the damage is, where on the toy it is concentrated, and how quickly the toy broke down, and combines this with shedding indicators to build a profile of each dog. From this profile we select toys and grooming supplies from our supplier network that fit that dogs chewing intensity, style, and coat needs, and we ship them in a monthly subscription box. Over time the profile gets better as the customer uploads more photos and gives feedback on how long each item lasted, creating a feedback loop that improves recommendations for that dog and for every other dog with a similar profile. We think of this as a data flywheel, where more subscribers means better models, which means better products, which means lower churn.

Market

The pet industry in the United States is large and growing, and dog ownership in particular represents a major share of that spending. Our target customer is the engaged dog owner, typically a millennial or Gen Z household, who treats their dog as a family member and is comfortable with subscriptions and apps. We estimate there are tens of millions of such households nationally, and if even a small percentage subscribed to a service like ours at a modest monthly price the market would be substantial. Our initial focus is on owners of medium and large dogs who are heavy chewers, since they feel the problem most acutely and spend the most replacing toys. We plan to start locally near our university and in a handful of similar college towns, and then expand through online channels. We have not yet done a rigorous bottom up market sizing and that is something we want to improve with mentorship.

Business Model

Our revenue comes from monthly subscription fees. We currently offer two tiers, a toy plan and a toy plus grooming plan, priced competitively with existing pet subscription boxes but positioned as more cost effective because products last longer. We source products from wholesale suppliers and a small number of private label manufacturers and earn a margin on each box after product cost, shipping, and packaging. Our early estimate of gross margin is in the

range of thirty five to forty five percent though this will depend on volume and supplier terms. Longer term we see additional revenue from selling anonymized insights to product makers who want to know how their products perform in the real world, and from a premium tier with advanced tracking. Customer acquisition is currently through word of mouth, campus groups, and local dog parks, and we expect to add social media and referral incentives. Our customer acquisition cost at scale is still unknown.

Competition

There are several existing pet subscription boxes that send curated toys and treats each month, and there are also large online retailers and big box stores that sell the same products one at a time. Most subscription boxes personalize only by dog size or by a short questionnaire, and none that we are aware of use actual wear evidence from the dogs own toys. Our differentiation is therefore the data and the personalization, along with the focus on durability. We recognize that competitors have larger audiences, bigger budgets, and established supplier relationships, and that a larger player could attempt to copy our approach if it proves valuable. Our defense is the proprietary dataset we build and the quality of our recommendations, but we acknowledge that this advantage is early and not yet proven at scale.

Team

Marisol Teague-Okonkwo is our chief executive and leads strategy, partnerships, and customer relationships. She has owned dogs her whole life and was the original source of the idea after a frustrating run of destroyed toys. Declan Hrubik is our chief technology officer and built the prototype app and the image analysis pipeline. He has studied computer science and has experience with machine learning coursework and side projects. Priyanka Vandersloot leads operations and finance, including supplier sourcing, fulfillment, and budgeting. All three of us are students at our university and are working on Bristlecone Pets alongside classes. We do not yet have an advisor with deep experience in the pet industry or in subscription retail, which we see as a gap.

Milestones and Financials

To date we have defined the core concept, built a working prototype, and formed the LLC. We launched a website and brought on our first external users, who tested the app and gave us feedback on the photo upload flow. Our first client has paid for a subscription box, which validated that at least some people will pay for the service. We have a small number of subscribers right now and we are still learning about retention. Our spending so far has been modest and has come from personal savings of the founders, covering the LLC formation, the website, early inventory, and cloud costs. We have not raised outside money. Our rough projection is to reach a few hundred subscribers within the next twelve months, which would produce recurring revenue that begins to cover our costs, although our detailed financial model is still being refined and several assumptions, particularly churn and shipping costs, are estimates.

What We Are Asking For

We are asking for funding to help us scale from our early users to a larger subscriber base, primarily to purchase inventory in larger quantities, improve our image analysis models with more training data, and run initial marketing tests. Beyond money, we are seeking mentorship from people with experience in consumer subscription businesses and the pet industry, introductions to suppliers and potential partners, and feedback on our market sizing, pricing, and financial model. We believe the competition would help us turn a promising early stage idea into a real and sustainable business, and we thank the judges for their time and consideration.